

Eight players fell into this price bracket; reminiscent of the previous category, the big brands slug it out here...no quarters given and none asked for!

The contenders consisted of two Apple nano's, a couple of Samsungs, two Sansas from Sandisk, and a solitary participant each from Cowon and Sony.

Features

Oh, Beautiful

Hiding between the fashion-statement-making nanos and the simple but extremely functional Sansas was beauty, pure and unmatched. Sony's NW-S705F is a gorgeous looking player, period. Uniquely sculpted, with an excellent matte finish, a maroon and glossy chrome body, this player has the best build quality we've seen so far. The OLED screen is tiny but ultra-crisp, and adds to the classy look. The player has a click-type slider to toggle between track and folder views—similar to its cheaper sibling in the previous category. The quality of the bundled in-ear type earplugs is also excellent.

Cowon's D2 is another looker—the large screen looks good, and is a touchscreen to boot! Although made of plastic, the build quality is very good.

Samsung dropped in another bombshell—the YP-K5. Although this player looks like a solid brick at first, it's a slider that opens to reveal reasonably powerful inbuilt speaker. Once again, the tastefully backlit touch button interface appears, although we must say the YP-K3 is much slimmer and looks better. Comparing the YP-K3 to the YP-K5 is like comparing a Miss Universe to a Miss World—who cares, we like them both!

The other Samsung (YP-T9) looks similar to the Philips 768 cell phone we reviewed last year—the sides curve in towards the edges. This is another sleek player, slim enough to fit your pocket without a bulge, and light enough too.

It's A Materialistic World

Feature-rich was synonymous with Cowon here—the D2 adds more features than you'd ever likely use, and then some. Besides a large 24-bit screen that you can operate entirely with your fingers, there's expansion (SD), photo and video support, and a number of track-playing options. The D2 is also the only Flash PMP here to feature an alarm, though it misses out on the calendar and contacts option.

The feature-rich Sansa players also score really high on the feature count—identical to the e250, except these have more storage. Another feature-rich little thing was Samsung's YP-T9, which handles photos and videos in addition to music, FM radio, and voice recording, besides having support for games.

The hot-looking Samsung YP-K5 comes with a decent feature set and ever better accessories. The least-loaded model would have to be the Sony NW-S705F, although in all

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fairness, we have to say it's a brilliant PMP in its own right.

Performance

At Rs 10,000+, you'd expect all these PMPs to excel at their bread and butter—playing music. With two customisable equaliser settings, the Sony NW-S705F is a great-sounding player with its bundled earplugs. Plugging in the Bose Intra Ears gives a further sound upgrade. Volumes are also good.

But then it gets better. Cowon's D2 actually manages to (gasp!) sound better than the iPod nano duo on the Bose earplugs. Excellent treble, completely neutral highs, and well-modulated vocals. Note that the nanos still have the edge when it comes to ear-pummelling bass; they go lower and give more of a rumble, and the D2 sounds a tad clearer. The difference between these players in terms of sheer audio quality is minute, and who the winner is depends largely on the genre of music you listen to. The nanos make Mark Knopfler's guitar come to life in *Sultans of Swing*, while Sony brings the tabla thumps and vocals in *Chand Sifarish* to life.



Cowon D2
An emphatic winner

The Sandisks cannot help but trail the trio above in terms of quality, and *Hotel California* was less delightful an overall experience as we remember it. The Samsung duo bring up the rear here, with the YP-K5 outperforming its feature rich sibling the YP-T9. The A2 has another ace up its sleeve—the battery life is a stellar 38 hours, absolutely unmatched! The nanos also have good battery life—a little under a day.

Perfect Dreams

If you plan on burning 15,000 odd bucks on a PMP, you better know exactly what you want. We also suggest investing in a good set of in-ear type earplugs like our reference set or Creative's EP630, another much cheaper yet good-performing set of earphones.

Then, take a serious look at Cowon's D2: at Rs 15,000, we'd have to be plumb crazy to put our gold elsewhere. It's got the looks, it's got the gimmicky touchscreen among a host of